



Plants for clay soil

Cool, shady borders on heavy clay soils may seem unpromising, but they can provide the fertile conditions that many plants enjoy.

Clay-rich soils offer a rich supply of nutrients and moisture for most of the year. There is plenty of choice for gardeners with lively color schemes in mind because dazzling maple, pink turtlehead, blue aster, and camellia of all hues will be happy in partial shade. Lighten up darker areas with the bright blooms of spiderwort and pigsqueak, or choose a more subdued palette of hellebore, anemone, and leafy hosta, which will also tolerate deep shade. To add an element of surprise to a design, spice up your beds with sweetly scented deutzia or sweet box.



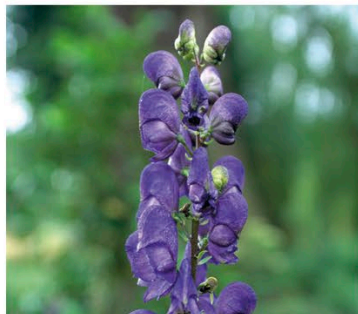
SHRUB MEDIUM

Acer palmatum var. *dissectum*

JAPANESE MAPLE This slow-growing shrub has a domed to cascading habit and produces deep purple lobed leaves with finely divided tapering "fingers." The foliage also sports rich fall color. Plant it in a sheltered site.

↑5ft (1.5m) ↔3ft (1m)

☹ Z6–8



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Aconitum 'Bressingham Spire'

MONKSHOOD This clump-forming perennial produces glossy, green, rounded, and deeply divided leaves. Erect spires of violet-purple flowers appear from midsummer to early fall. May need staking. Toxic if ingested.

↑3ft (1m) ↔20in (50cm)

☹ ! Z3–7



PERENNIAL LARGE

Actaea racemosa

BLACK COHOSH This upright perennial has deeply divided leaves, above which appear bottlebrush-like spikes of white flowers in midsummer. The dried brown seedheads are also attractive. Water well during dry spells.

↑5ft (1.5m) ↔24in (60cm)

☹ Z3–8 (N)



PERENNIAL SMALL

Actaea rubra

RED BANEERRY A clump-forming perennial with leaves divided into lobed and toothed leaflets and oval, fluffy white flower heads from mid-spring to early summer followed by shiny red, poisonous berries. Water well in dry spells.

↑20in (50cm) ↔12in (30cm)

☹ ! Z3–8 (N)



TREE LARGE

Acer davidii

SNAKEBARK MAPLE This multistemmed, deciduous tree has white-streaked green bark and dark purple shoots. The oval, tapered green leaves turn red in fall. Hanging clusters of yellow flowers appear in spring. Grow in a sheltered site.

↑↔50ft (15m)

☹ Z5–7



PERENNIAL LARGE

Actaea simplex 'Brunette'

BUGBANE An upright perennial with dark purple divided foliage. From early- to mid-fall, narrow, arching bottlebrush flowers appear on slender stems. The tiny off-white blooms are tinged purple. Plant in drifts; water well during dry spells.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔24in (60cm)

☹ Z4–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

Aconitum napellus

MONKSHOOD An upright perennial with deeply divided dark green foliage and tall spires of indigo-blue blooms that appear from mid- to late summer and need staking. Plants tolerate poor drainage. Toxic if ingested.

↑5ft (1.5m) ↔12in (30cm)

☹ ! Z3–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Ajuga reptans 'Atropurpurea'

BUGLEWEED An evergreen ground-cover perennial, it spreads freely by runners. It has small rosettes of glossy, deep bronze-purple leaves and short spikes of blue spring blooms, which attract bumblebees. Considered invasive in some areas.

↑6in (15cm) ↔3ft (1m)

☹ Z3–9